PILOT FEEDBACK REVIEW · NOVEMBER 2026

Listening to students

What the pilot cohort told us in four weeks of the stripped-back app, and what has already changed because of it.



Prepared for PwC · All data in this deck comes from the stripped-back pilot app: study sessions, the island and the modules, with no exam practice

nextstepuni

THE SHORT ANSWER · STRIPPED-BACK APP DATA

Feedback is already changing the product, not waiting for a review at the end of the year

41

student messages

Real, anonymous, sent from inside the stripped-back app. Test entries removed.

16

changes already live

Each one traceable to a specific message or a workshop observation.

3

days, median

From a student writing the message to the change being live for everyone.

The loop is not a plan. It is a button on every page of the app, a review inbox, and a deploy pipeline that puts the fix in front of the same students within days.

Feedback inbox of the stripped-back pilot app, 18 August to 4 November 2026; production release log.

HOW IT WORKS

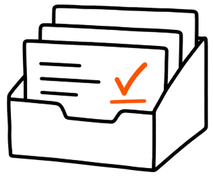
A feedback button on every page, one inbox, and a deploy the same week



01

Listen

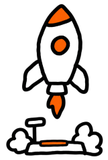
A feedback button on every page of the app. One tap, type, send. Plus three in-person workshop days with the pilot cohort.



02

Triage

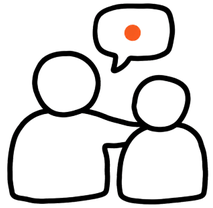
Every message lands in a review inbox and moves through New, Reviewing, Planned and Fixed. Nothing is deleted.



03

Ship

Fixes go straight to the live app. No release train, no waiting for a term to end. Most land the same week.



04

Tell them

A What's New note in the app shows students the change they asked for, so the next message comes sooner.

Anonymous by design: a message carries no name, email or school, and only the platform administrator can read the inbox.

WHERE IT CAME FROM · STRIPPED-BACK APP DATA

Four in five messages were ideas, not complaints: students were telling us what to build next

29

sent during the workshops

Three in-school sessions in mid-October, on school iPads, inside the app.

12

sent from home

Students who kept using the app after the workshop, up to 4 November.

3

on the iPad app

The rest came from the web app on school devices.

WHAT STUDENTS CHOSE TO SEND, BY CATEGORY



32 feature ideas **5** something else **4** something is broken

Feedback inbox of the stripped-back pilot app, by category and date sent, test entries removed.

IN THEIR OWN WORDS · STRIPPED-BACK APP DATA

Unedited: a sixteen-year-old on a school iPad, taking thirty seconds to tell us something

“my study time keeps getting deleted after i log it for some reason”

12 OCT · IPAD APP

“add a button that says ‘Keep going?’ and add a few more minutes to keep going with your session”

5 OCT · FROM HOME

“The island feature is sooooo slowwwww pls fix it.”

12 OCT · WORKSHOP

“I would like to see the points bars where I’m currently at and what my goal points are”

12 OCT · WORKSHOP

“I want LCVP as a subject · Are you able to add polish as a language · Add Romanian”

12 TO 22 OCT · 15 MESSAGES ON SUBJECTS

“I would like questions on the study topic at the end of the study sessions to test me on”

16 OCT · WORKSHOP

“you’re the first dev team that seems to actually listen to their users, and I’m eager to help as much as I can.” 15 Oct

Verbatim from the feedback inbox, spelling as written. Longer messages are trimmed; nothing is reworded.

Six things students kept asking for, and five of them already answered in the live app

	**My subject isn't here**	LCVP, Polish, Romanian, Portuguese, Ukrainian, Russian, Chinese, LCPE and the LCA courses	15 msgs	SHIPPED 18 OCT
	**Test me on what I studied**	A quiz after a session, flashcards, a test per subject, answering before seeing the answer	7 msgs	SHIPPED 27 AND 31 OCT
	**The island**	Slow on school iPads, no way to delete a misplaced tile, more to do with the points earned	6 msgs	SHIPPED 13 AND 14 OCT
	**The study timer**	Lost study time, a Keep going button, a stopwatch, a timer that survives switching apps	5 msgs	SHIPPED 14 TO 18 OCT
	**Show me my progress**	Points against goal, a view of onboarding choices, changing the exam date, seeing classmates	5 msgs	SHIPPED 14 TO 18 OCT
	**Getting in, and the rest**	A reset link that didn't work, studying live with friends, a doubt about the study planner	4 msgs	1 SHIPPED · 3 IN REVIEW

Some messages ask for two things, so the theme counts add to 42 across 41 messages.

Timer problems reported on a Monday were live-fixed by the Wednesday



A STUDENT WROTE	NOW IN THE LIVE APP	LIVE ON
“my study time keeps getting deleted after i log it for some reason” · 12 Oct	A running session survives an iPad tab reload, and a finished session waits in an outbox until the server confirms it was saved. Reproduced, fixed, tested.	**14 Oct** 2 days
“the timer didnt shut off when on other apps... maybe a miniplayer” · 12 Oct, and “minimise the timer” · 19 Oct	A minimised timer that keeps counting across every tool in the app and while the student is in another app, with pause, resume and tap to return.	**15 Oct** 3 days
“add a button that says ‘Keep going?’” and a stopwatch mode · 5 Oct	Keep going adds 5, 10 or 15 minutes to the same session when the countdown ends, with a small bonus for finishing. An open-ended mode counts up until the student stops.	**15 Oct** 10 days
“having to fully unlock [the iPad] to check how much time is left detracts from its purpose” · 15 Oct	The timer on the iPhone and iPad Lock Screen as a Live Activity, and a notification when time is up. Asked once, in context, never on launch.	**18 Oct** 3 days

Days are calendar days from the message to the change being live for every student. Dates from the production release log.

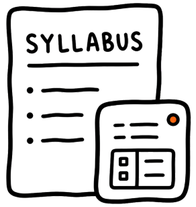
Three students said the island was slow on school iPads; it was fast the next day



A STUDENT WROTE	NOW IN THE LIVE APP	LIVE ON
“The island feature is sooooo slowwwww pls fix it.” “The island mode is a bit slow on Ipad.” “The game is really slow and laggy.” · 12 Oct, three students	The island now moves as one layer and repaints once per drag instead of 119 times. Artwork rebuilt for school iPads: 24 MB of tiles became 2 MB, and the work per drag fell from 2.25 s to 0.14 s.	**13 Oct** 1 day
“add a ‘delete’ option on the build your own island, i have made a mistake on my island and i cannot delete it” · 12 Oct, two students	Tiles can be removed and swapped. A mistake no longer costs the student the points they studied for.	**14 Oct** 2 days
“I would like to see the points bars where I’m currently at and what my goal points are” · 12 Oct	My Progress shows current CAO points against goal points, and the onboarding grades step explains how points work at every level.	**14 Oct** 2 days
“i widsh there was view for all the stuff I did on onboarding” · 12 Oct	A Your setup page: everything chosen at onboarding in one place, editable, reachable from the sidebar and on iPad.	**14 Oct** 2 days

Island performance measured in Chrome with a 4x CPU throttle on the same scripted drag, before and after.

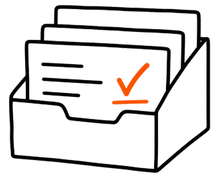
Fifteen students asked for a missing subject; every SEC subject was in the app within six days



A STUDENT WROTE	NOW IN THE LIVE APP	LIVE ON
“I want LCVP as a subject.” “Are you able to add polish as a language.” “Add Romanian.” Plus Portuguese, Ukrainian, Russian, Chinese, LCPE and the LCA courses · 15 messages, 5 to 22 Oct	Every subject the State Examinations Commission examines is now in onboarding: every language, PE, and LCVP on its own Distinction, Merit, Pass scale. Foundation level Maths and Irish. The full LCA course list. Search finds a subject by its other names.	**18 Oct** 6 days
“i cant change my exam date” · 16 Oct	The exam date is editable on Your setup, so a student who picked the wrong year is not stuck with it.	**18 Oct** 2 days
“your password reset link doesn’t work for me” · 12 Oct	Reproduced: asking for a second reset email cancelled the first. The app now says only the newest link works, waits before resending, and a dead link explains why and sends a fresh one.	**15 Oct** 3 days
Observed at the first workshop · 12 Oct: students struggling to get into new accounts on shared school iPads	A failed sign-in now says why, in plain words. Sign-up suggests a fix when a school email is mistyped. Failure reasons are recorded anonymously so each workshop shows what actually went wrong.	**15 Oct** 3 days

Days for the subjects row count from the first message on 12 Oct; the last of the fifteen arrived four days after the change went live.

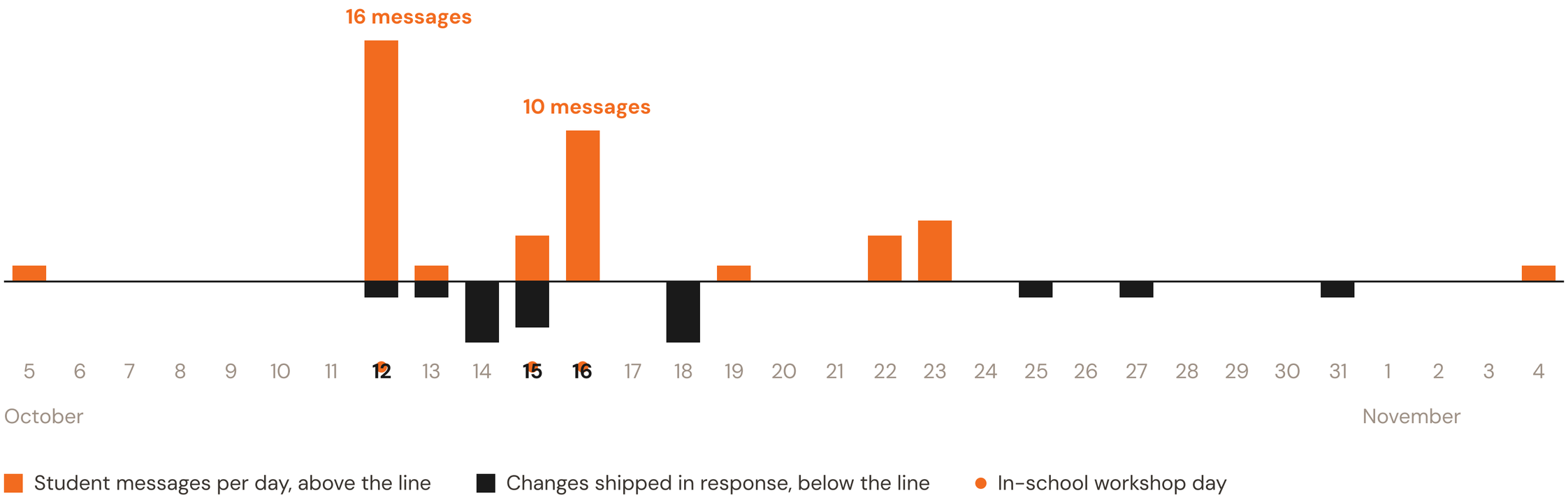
Students asked to be tested on what they had just studied; the quiz is live and feeds revision



A STUDENT WROTE	NOW IN THE LIVE APP	LIVE ON
“after every session we get short test to help us and see if we have improved.” “questions on the study topic at the end of the study sessions to test me on.” · 16 Oct, two students, and again 23 Oct	After a session is saved, four short real exam questions on the topics studied. The student answers, reveals the official marking scheme, and ticks what the examiner would have given. Results feed a spaced-repetition review deck. A quiz never costs study time, and there is an off switch.	**27 Oct** 11 days
“I would like to answer questions before seeing the answer” · 23 Oct	Past-paper questions can be attempted before the scheme is revealed, so a student commits to an answer first.	**31 Oct** 8 days
“I would love if there were more questions … for geography” · 16 Oct	The Geography revision deck was completed for every paper from 2010 to 2026, roughly doubling it.	**25 Oct** 9 days
“Could add flashcards to make studying and revision before an exam easier” · 16 Oct	The flashcard deck built from official marking schemes, more than 42,000 cards across every subject, is now named as flashcards where students look for it, and the end-of-session quiz feeds it.	**18 Oct** 2 days

Every question and answer in these features comes from a State Examinations Commission paper or marking scheme, with its source shown.

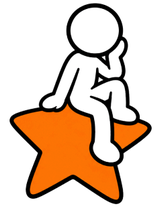
Changes shipped in the days after each workshop, not at the end of the term



Stripped-back pilot app, 5 October to 4 November 2026. One earlier message from 18 August, before the pilot, is not shown.

STILL ON THE LIST · STRIPPED-BACK APP DATA

Not everything gets built, and every message keeps its place in the inbox with a reason



“a quiz or a test for each subject so that people know where to start”	23 OCT	IN DESIGN
Irish oral: “Speaking into the app, seeing it getting better and better each time.”	23 OCT	IN DESIGN
“THE ABILITY TO STUDY LIVE!” with classmates	18 AUG	PLANNED
Keep me signed in on this device, for shared school iPads	EVERY WORKSHOP	NEXT
“a section accessible for college students because i would love to continue using this app after secondary”	12 OCT	GRADUATES KEEP ACCESS · PRODUCT DECISION PENDING
“I wish we could look at other people progress too”	4 NOV	ISLANDS ARE SHAREABLE · PROGRESS NEEDS A PRIVACY DECISION
“the quite capybara, maybe once you click on it, there could be other animal options”	12 OCT	PARKED, FONDLY

Review inbox status as of 4 November 2026.

THE STRIPPED-BACK PILOT AND THE FULL APP

With three surfaces to react to, the pilot cohort's top request was exam practice. It is already built.

WHAT THE PILOT HAS HAD



Study sessions and the timer



The Journey island
Earned by studying



The Learning Lab modules

The stripped-back app. No exam practice. Every message in this deck came from here.

WHAT THEY ASKED FOR

"a short test after every session"

"flashcards for revision before an exam"

"a test for each subject so people know where to start"

"answer questions before seeing the answer"

"more questions for geography"

ALREADY BUILT, IN THE FULL APP



Paper Trail
Every SEC paper, 1995 to 2026, with its scheme; Topic Atlas and Ways In



Mark Bank
42,000+ scheme-backed flashcards, self-marked



Command-Word Reflex
Spot the command word in real questions



Coursework Studio
Evidence, thinking and next steps for projects

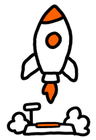


War Room, Planner, Points Passport
The Launchpad tools around the exam work

Every question and card in the full app comes from a State Examinations Commission paper or marking scheme and names its source.

SEPTEMBER 2027

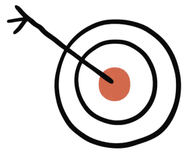
A full year of the full app gives the next cohort a platform that has already been tested by students



NOV TO DEC 2026

Full app in the pilot schools

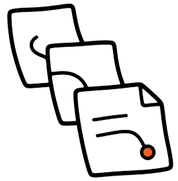
Exam practice switched on for students who have already asked for it. A second feedback round while the loop is warm.



JAN TO FEB 2027

Mocks

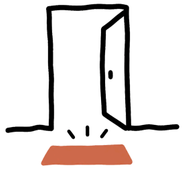
The past-paper and marking-scheme tools used under real pressure, by students who will tell us what breaks.



MAR TO JUN 2027

The run-in and the exam

The only chance this year to see how the whole platform behaves across a full Leaving Cert season.



SEP 2027

A new cohort starts on a tested platform

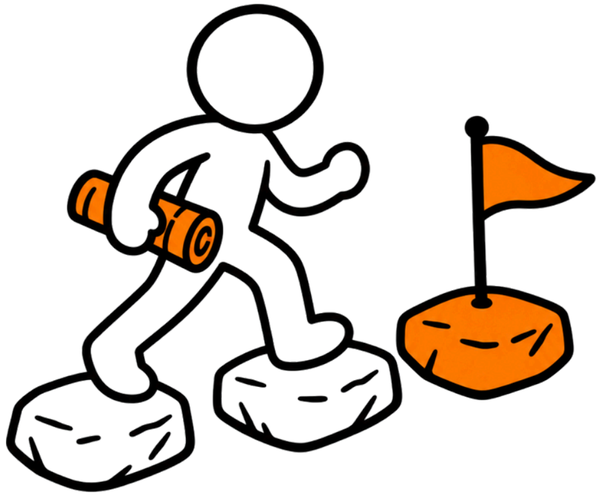
Every tool shaped by a year of real student feedback, not a launch-week guess.

Three surfaces produced 41 messages and 16 shipped changes in four weeks. The full app has thirteen. Feedback on the stripped-back app cannot improve tools the students never see.

The loop, the inbox and the deploy pipeline shown in this deck already run on the full app. No new build is needed.

THE ASK

Roll out the full app to the pilot schools this year.



01

The loop is proven

41 messages, 16 changes live, a median of three days from message to fix.

02

The demand is theirs

Exam practice was the pilot cohort's own top feature request. It is already built.

03

The window is now

The January mocks are the one real test before September 2027. The next cohort inherits whatever we learn.

nextstepuniinfo@gmail.com · Every figure in this deck can be traced to the feedback inbox or the release log on request